out in cremation grounds and covers his body with ash from the funeral pyres. He ‘challenges any facile distinctions between sacred and profane, rich and poor, high and low’. He has long appealed to the rebels, misfits and renunciants in Hindu society (but not only them; his domesticated forms also appeal to conservatives). In short, not a bad presiding deity for a multicultural city.

One evening I meet Amitabh Bhattacharya, an erudite Banarasi and retired professor of journalism. A polyglot known for his deep knowledge of the city, he rattles off an impressive list of faith groups that have called Varanasi home and speaks of its long ethos of pluralism. Varanasi’s cultural essence, he says, has been more spiritual than religious, which is why so many thinkers were drawn to it. It took in all kinds of groups and *mostly* avoided the four pitfalls of religion: fanaticism, communalism, fundamentalism and forced conversion. Even the strictures of caste were more fluid in Varanasi, he says, and its casteism relatively milder. ‘Where else can a Shudra Yadav casually ask a Brahmin panda [priest] on the ghats to mind his shoes while he takes a dip in the river, as happens here?’ His example strikes me as feeble in this day and age, but his point still seems plausible as long as we take ‘relatively milder’ as the operative phrase.

But recent decades have brought unwelcome changes, Bhattacharya says. A big political party and its affiliated groups are hell-bent on turning this into a parochially Hindu city. Their push to saffronize has caused immense damage already, polarizing communities and bringing out the worst in people. Communal-minded thugs and criminals now compete for the elected office. A kind of madness has taken hold. They want revenge for past wrongs against today’s Muslims. Will the good people of the city defeat such forces, he wonders pensively, or will they lose much of their pluralistic soul and usher in a spiritually arid city not worth inhabiting?

Much of Varanasi, directly or indirectly, is sustained by pilgrimage and tourism. Among the professional communities central to it, and which outsiders encounter more often, are the Mallahs, the Doms, the weavers and the pandas, each a complex social world in itself. Many old Varanasi neighbourhoods above the ghats exhibit strong ethnic concentrations. Muslim areas may adjoin and overlap with Yadav, Mallah or Dhobi areas. The old town also has generations-old settlements of Tamilians, Bengalis, Gujaratis and others. I meet many people in Varanasi, but I’m especially